

ONE MORE TIME CM Jagan Reddy at the 'Siddham' poll campaign rally in Vizag

ANI

ANDHRA PRADESH

BRACING FOR THE BATTLE

By Amarnath K. Menon

"*Nenu siddham, meeru siddhama* (I am ready, are you ready)," was Chief Minister Y.S. Jagan Reddy's war cry as he launched the poll campaign for the 175 legislative assembly and 25 Lok Sabha seats in Andhra Pradesh on January 27. Events have moved fast in the following month, with a mini exodus from his Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP). On February 21, Rajya Sabha MP Vemireddy Prabhakar Reddy, a prominent industrialist who was a close aide of Jagan's father and former Andhra CM Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, became the latest to quit the party. His sister Y.S. Sharmila's sudden shift to the Congress in late January is what had set the ball rolling. Being up against kith and kin expectedly dredges up the metaphors of an epic battle. "I am not Abhimanyu, who fell prey to the Opposition's deceit. I am Arjuna," the 51-year-old Jagan had declared, beating a drum, as a massive crowd roared at the rally in Sangivalasa near Visakhapatnam.

The YSRCP's re-election campaign banks heavily on a bouquet of direct benefit transfer (DBT) schemes. Glossing over the need to attract investment, much of the state's resources were diverted to this outreach—about Rs 2.53 lakh crore were spent and 213,000 government jobs created in the past 56 months. Unlike the counsel received by the epic hero, though, all the good karma is meant to bear fruit. Andhra Pradesh will likely vote in the initial stages of the multi-phase general election in April-May, going by the pattern set the previous two times.

"The YSRCP must make a clean sweep to ensure the continuation of welfare schemes for the next 25 years," Jagan says, urging party activists to go door to door and convey the message. Poll analysts point out that the "positive impact" of the DBT measures will be critical if he is to win a second successive term. One good thing is that it can't be fudged: the schemes are monitored by a robust village secretariat system pioneered by Jagan as a grassroots governance initiative.

JAGAN HAS DROPPED MANY OF THE UNPOPULAR MLAs AND MPs. EVEN SO, A 2019-LIKE SWEEP SEEMS UNLIKELY

Accountability can take many forms. Learning from the recent defeat of Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) leader K. Chandrashekar Rao in neighbouring Telangana, Jagan has shifted or dropped many 'unpopular' MLAs and MPs, hoping it will counter any anti-incumbency that has set in. Feedback has been taken from poll strategists and even the state police intelligence to assess the winnability of candidates. Even so, a repeat of the 2019 results when the YSRCP won 151 assembly and 22 Lok Sabha seats looks highly unlikely.

Moreover, the rivals led by Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP) hope to close ranks and avoid a split in the anti-YSRCP vote. Naidu is trying to get actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party (JSP) and the BJP on his side to put up a combined fight. The TDP has been delaying the announcement of its candidates for the elections for the same reason, waiting for a seat-sharing pact to be finalised. The saffron party reportedly wants six Lok Sabha seats and anything between 10 and 20